

STUDY N° 7

(Op. 25)

It has become so usual to call this Study by the name of « Study for the Left Hand », that this has gradually altered the expressional significance of the composition and perverted its educational value to such an extent that, in our opinion, the somewhat traditional interpretation deriving from this habit calls for being counteracted.

Consequently, we should like to warn the performer against any summary conception which might lead him to only emphasize the figure of the bass — either by playing with too much feeling, or exaggerated volume of sound — while confining the right hand part to be but a discreet accompaniment.

On the contrary, the poetical conception and the real technical interest afforded by this Study rest on a proper distribution of the tone-value of the two parts, and on the exact quality of touch required for binding — though not blending — the notes together while retaining to each its expressive individuality.

A truly musical interpretation of this admirable piece demands that, above the poignant lament of the bass, fraught with passion and regret, devoured — it would seem — by a dramatic and unconsolable love, should soar aloft, far away but penetrating and perfectly distinct, the wounded treble, sad and tender of the right hand.

In order to render the expressive meaning of the composition, upon which we have just enlarged, it will be of course necessary to practise each hand first of all separately, so that both should acquire the excellence and homogeneous quality of tone required.

First, for the left hand, to increase and ensure an equal expressive power for each finger, practise the following exercises using the weight of the hand :

to be continued with the same fingering

to be transposed on all the degrees of the chromatic scale

Then :

same fingerings

Practise the above arpeggio figures on all the degrees of the chromatic scale, in a slow tempo and strictly legato.

Next, diatonic and chromatic scales in all keys, using the following finger-successions :

Slow and legato

playing *p* to *f*, and *f* to *p* throughout, taking great care that grading of tone should be obtained strictly by greater or lesser weight of the hand — only the finger transmitting the latter to the key, and the wrist remaining flexible whatever the grade.

The fingers should be raised with more precision only when playing demisemiquaver or grace-note figures which should be practised with the following rhythms :

(1) We insist here on the high technical value of practising dynamics in slow tempo, as this ensures muscular development of the fingers.

Further, practice the whole left hand part, in long fragments, endeavouring that the declamation should be as natural and pathetic as if the notes themselves were passionate utterances. Exception being made, however, for bars 28 to 36, in which the left hand should softly glide over the keys, letting only the right hand call forth the melancholy sweetness of the past.

As regards the right hand, the necessity of separating the upper voice from the accompanying harmonies, will demand preparatory work, slightly similar to that we recommended for Study No 3 (Op. 10).

First, practise the upper melodic line giving full attention to its very expressive punctuation.

Then, adding the accompaniment, practise as follows :



Further, combine the two hands, giving full attention to the evenness of tone mentioned at the beginning of the present analysis, of which the general scheme may be suggested as follows :

Upper melodic line : *mp* penetrating
 Accompaniment : *pp* but well-sustained
 Lower melodic line : *mf* eloquent

Keep the fingers of the right hand which are playing the accompanying part in contact with the keys throughout, in order to prevent any abrupt attack.

By practising in this manner, it will be possible on double escapement keyboards to emit the sound with utmost softness by not letting the keys come back to their original position.

The rare pedal-marks indicated by Chopin are obviously insufficient for an expressive rendering of this Study. We advise using the pedal almost constantly ; it should, however, be changed frequently — though unobtrusively — so as to prevent any stagnation of sound in the lower register of the piano : and on the condition also that this practically permanent use of the pedal should not, because of the necessity of linking up all the notes of the melody, disregard the dues of harmonic correspondancy.

ALFRED CORTOT

STUDY N° 7

(Op. 25)

M.S. Original = ♩ = 60 Edit. Schlesinger = ♩ = 66

Lento ($\text{♩} = 66$)

3 min. 50

(quasi recitativo)

p

pp

Red. * *Red.* *

Red. (molto cantabile)

pp

Red. *

dim.

pp

ten.

Red. *

(*) Execute
thus :



25

27

30 *Riten.* *fff*

31 *pp* *a Tempo* *fz* *p* *pp* *Red.* *** *Red.* *** *Red.* *** *Red.* *** *Red.* ***

35 *ppp* *smorz.* *Red.* *** *Red.* *** *Red.* *** *Red.* ***

39 *pp* *tr* *Red.* ***

* Execute
thus :



Poco rit. *a Tempo*

44 *ten.* *ten.* *pp* *f* *Ad.* *

49 (5) *f* *cresc.* *Ad.* *

54 *f* *cresc.* *Ad.* *

57 *tr* *pp* *Riten.*

61 *pp* *Riten.*

66 *f* *ten.* *diminuendo* *smorzando* *pp* *Ad.* *